

SPOT CHECK

SKATESPOTS FIELD MANUAL · Nº03

THE CUSTOM <select> ARROW

One focused chapter: how — and why — to restyle a native dropdown that refuses to look like anything else on the page.

1 chapter

Self-test

NewSpotCard — Difficulty field

► CONTENTS

01 Styling a native <select>

● CONCEPT

● GOTCHA

KEYWORDS

replaced element

appearance: none

data URI

background-position

— WHAT

The Difficulty dropdown in `NewSpotCard` needed to look like the rest of the dark, custom-designed form instead of a bare browser default box with a stock arrow.

— HOW

`appearance: none` (plus `-webkit-` / `-moz-` prefixes) strips *all* native chrome from the element — border, background, and the arrow together. A `background-image` — a tiny chevron SVG embedded as a data URI — draws a replacement arrow back in,

positioned with `background-position` and kept clear of the option text with extra `padding-right`.

```
.select {
  appearance: none;
  -webkit-appearance: none;
  background-color: var(--color-border);
  background-image: url("data:image/svg+xml,%3Csvg ...%3E");
  background-repeat: no-repeat;
  background-position: right 12px center;
  border: 1px solid transparent;
  border-radius: 9px;
  padding: 10px 36px 10px 12px; /* room for the arrow */
}
```

— WHY

A `<select>` is a **replaced element** — the browser renders its entire box as one opaque widget it controls internally. There's no "inside" to insert a `<span>` or a `::after` pseudo-element into to fake an arrow. Once `appearance: none` clears the native chrome, `background-image` is the one styling channel still available on the element itself — so it becomes the standard trick for rebuilding what was just stripped away.

Gotcha: `var()` / `currentColor` do not resolve inside a data-URI SVG. The chevron's stroke color has to be a hardcoded hex (`stroke='%239ca3af'`), not a CSS custom property — the SVG isn't part of the live DOM, so it can't inherit anything from its parent's CSS. Same root cause as Study Sheet 01, Item 10 (`var()` not working in SVG presentation attributes) — same rule, different location it bites you.

— IDEA TO CONSIDER

◆ ZOOM OUT

This generalizes past one dropdown: *any* replaced element — `<video>` controls, `<input type="file">`, `<input type="range">` — resists normal styling for the identical reason. Recognizing *when you're fighting the platform* (a replaced element or

closed shadow tree) versus when you've simply forgotten a class is a debugging skill that transfers directly to every one of those elements.

A Glossary

Replaced element

An element (like `<select>`, `<video>`, `<img>`) whose rendered content the browser controls internally — you can't insert child elements to alter it the way you can with a normal element.

Data URI

A resource (here, a small SVG) embedded directly inside a CSS/HTML value as text, instead of linking to a separate file — no extra network request.

currentColor

A CSS keyword that resolves to the element's own `color` value — but only inside live CSS on the live DOM, which a data-URI SVG is not part of.

B Self-test

Answer aloud *before* opening each.

Q1 Why can't you put a `<span>` arrow inside a `<select>` the way you would inside a `<div>` ? ▶

Q2 What does `appearance: none` remove, and what goes with it? ▶

Q3 Why is the arrow's color a hardcoded hex instead of `var(--color-text-muted)` ? ▶

Q4 Why does the select need extra `padding-right` but not extra `padding-left` ? ▶

C Study links

- ↗ [MDN — appearance](#)
- ↗ [MDN — Replaced elements](#)
- ↗ [MDN — data: URIs](#)

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SkateSpots Field Manual N°03 · built while wrapping up NewSpotCard's Difficulty field.